see at least a metaphorical connection between a hovercraft and an aircraft. After al , the Wright Brothers made the first aeroplane after fixing bicycles for seven years! I saw in the GEM project great opportunities for ingenuity and growth. We went straight into hardware development after spending a few months on the drawing board.

There is always the danger that a person with my kind of background— rural or smal -town, middle-class, whose parents had limited education— wil retreat into a corner and remain there struggling for bare existence, unless some great turn of circumstance propels him into a more favourable environment. I knew I had to create my own opportunities.

Part by part, subsystem by subsystem, stage by stage, things started moving. Working on this project, I learned that once your mind stretches to a new level it never goes back to its original dimension.

At that time VK Krishna Menon was the Defence Minister. He was keenly interested in the progress of our smal project, which he envisioned as the beginning of the indigenous development of India’s defence equipment.